The Prepare-Now Care Roadmap Checklist

What to organize, talk over and keep an eye on while Mom is well.

Mom is well. One of you wants to start touring places, one of you would rather not talk about it, and you'd like something useful to do in between. These are the things worth organizing and talking over while there is no date on anything. Take them in any order. Check what you've done. Anything unchecked is something that hasn't come up yet, and that is all it is.

Organize

- [ ] Every idea anyone in the family has had about getting ready, on one list, including the ones you think are too early.
- [ ] That list sorted in two: preparation that would be useful whatever happens, and decisions that aren't due.
- [ ] The decisions you're not making yet, kept on the page as things the family has chosen to wait on.
- [ ] What you already have about how Mom's days go, and the questions it left open, gathered in one place.
- [ ] One planning file, on paper or shared online, where all of this lives.

Talk over

- [ ] What Mom herself would like to get ready, and what she'd rather leave alone for now. [1]
- [ ] Who keeps the planning file up to date, and who Mom is happy to have read it.
- [ ] Which piece of the preparation each person would be willing to take. Collect offers; don't hand anything out. [1]
- [ ] How much of the preparation has ended up with one person so far, and whether that's realistic.
- [ ] Which questions the family can't answer itself, and who would take each one to a professional.

Keep an eye on

- [ ] A day to look at the list again, written at the bottom of the page. [2]
- [ ] The everyday changes that would bring the family back to it sooner: in Mom's routine, in the people who help her, or in the household. Write down the ones the family names. [2]
- [ ] Which of those changes Mom would want you to notice, and which she'd rather tell you about herself.

What this checklist doesn't do

It helps you organize, talk and keep an eye on things. It doesn't say where Mom should live, when anything should change, who has to do what, or what a change in her days would mean. Nothing on it adds up to a score. A page with every box checked is still preparation, with every decision left where it was.

Ready for the next step?

You've seen what's worth organizing and talking over now, and nothing has been decided for Mom. The care interview adds the picture the plan rests on: it walks you through her situation as it is today, area by area, so the family has something to compare against when it looks again, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Items marked 1 follow AARP's planning guide for families, which starts from the wishes of the person the plan is about and asks each person what they'd prefer to take on. Items marked 2 follow the Family Caregiver Alliance's advice to meet again regularly, and when the situation changes. The rest come from the Family Care Roadmap's own working list for this step.

1. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting